

a storable, labor-intensive staple, introduced alongside new immigrant populations, plausibly accelerated those existing tendencies toward social differentiation, a pattern archaeologists have observed in agricultural transitions across many other world regions.

The archaeological evidence for the Jomon-to-Yayoi transition resists any simple story of abrupt replacement. Zooarchaeological and isotopic evidence show that coastal Jomon communities relied on a broad, seasonally structured diet in which shellfish buffered risk rather than supplying most calories. Archaeobotanical and radiocarbon evidence show that rice arrived first as a ritual crop in the Central Highlands before spreading economically from northern Kyushu, propelled by migrations tied to political and climatic disruption on the Asian mainland. And residue, isotopic, and ethnoarchaeological evidence together show that the resulting subsistence systems coexisted, sometimes for centuries, before agriculture finally came to predominate. What changed most fundamentally, then, was not simply the presence of rice on the table but the underlying logic of subsistence itself: a move from resources that were immediately available and broadly accessible toward a staple that demanded sustained labor investment and opened new possibilities for storage, surplus, and social inequality. Additional isotopic sampling from underrepresented regions of eastern Japan, and further direct radiocarbon dating of early rice remains, would help clarify how evenly this transition actually proceeded across the archipelago. Even so, the methodologically diverse evidence assembled here already makes clear that the shift from shellfish to rice was not a single, local decision. It was the plausible outcome of a gradual, geographically variable renegotiation of how people related to food, one ultimately set in motion by forces well beyond the Jomon world itself. 

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